

WOMB OF SHADOWS

A GOTNA Novel

Roguenealer Stevens

Sample Chapters

Chapters 1-3 & Synapse 01

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WOMB OF SHADOWS - Book One of the GOTNA Trilogy

CONTENTS

Chapter One: The Quiet Fracture

Synapse 01: The Calculus of Zero

Chapter Two: Whispers in the Flesh

Chapter Three: The Intern

CHAPTER ONE

The Quiet Fracture

The baby did not cry. That was the first thing Dr. Evelyn Hart noticed and the last thing she would ever forgive. Three weeks after the delivery, in the half-dark of the neonatal ward at Apex Genomics, Evelyn held her daughter against her chest and listened to the silence where a voice should have been. The monitors spoke instead--steady, indifferent beeps measuring a life in voltage. Somewhere down the corridor a centrifuge spun with the low patience of a machine that would outlast everyone in the building. The air smelled of rubbing alcohol and recycled breath and the particular staleness of a room where people wait for results that never come fast enough. Nunnally was three weeks old. She weighed five pounds and four ounces. Her eyes were open. They saw nothing. Milky veils covered both irises, dense as cataracts, turning the world behind them to fog. Her mouth moved in small shapes--lips parting, tongue pressing forward, the mechanics of speech rehearsing in miniature without producing sound. No cry. No coo. Not even the thin, reedy wail that premature infants make, the one that sounds like a question. Just effort, meeting emptiness. Her ears were malformed: delicate folds that had never finished closing, cartilage curled in on itself as though the body had lost interest partway through. And her arms-- Evelyn looked at the arms every time. She could not stop. They ended in smooth, rounded nubs just below the elbows. The skin stretched taut and seamless over absence, as if the blueprint for the rest had simply been revoked. No scarring, no suggestion of trauma. Completion, refused.

The doctors used words like multifactorial and unprecedented and congenital syndrome of unknown etiology. Language shaped to sound like understanding while admitting none. Someone from genetics had mentioned a possible teratogenic event--environmental exposure during the first trimester--and someone else had quietly referenced Evelyn's long hours in the RNA lab. They spoke the way witnesses describe a house fire: unanimous that it happened, silent on who struck the match. Evelyn didn't care what they called it. Naming had never rebuilt anything. She pressed her lips to the baby's temple. Nunnally's skin was warm and thin, tasting of soap and the faint mineral salt of a body too new to have accumulated its own smell. Beneath it, something moved. Not muscle. Not reflex. A low internal shifting, wet and rhythmic, like cartilage testing its own edges. Click. The sound was barely there. Organic. Intimate. Coming from inside the left nub, where the arm should have continued. A small, wet articulation--bone-against-bone, or something not yet bone, pressing outward in slow, blind repetition. Click. Click. Evelyn's hand tightened on the baby's back. She told herself it was normal. Settling tissue. Cartilage remnants. The body doing inventory on what it had and what it lacked. But the sound didn't settle. It continued--even, patient, as if something inside the nub was knocking on a door it expected to open. A nurse came in to adjust the IV and left without meeting Evelyn's eyes. The room dimmed as the overhead fluorescents cycled to their evening setting. Evelyn kept rocking, kept listening. She was thirty-nine years old. She had spent the last eleven years at the frontier of messenger RNA therapeutics--designing molecular instruction sets that could reprogram living tissue at the cellular level. She had watched tumors dissolve under the right sequence. She had seen paralyzed nerve fibers refire after a single injection of a vector she'd built from scratch. She understood, with the certainty of someone who had done it, that the body was not fixed. It was not destiny. It was a draft, and drafts could be revised. But all of that was academic medicine. Peer-reviewed. Ethics-approved. Conducted on consenting adults who signed waivers. Almost all of it. There had been one exception--a nineteen-year-old at Johns Hopkins, three years ago, a spinal glioblastoma eating her alive faster than

the review board could approve dose adjustments. Evelyn had gone off-protocol at two in the morning. A single unauthorized escalation. The girl's tumor shrank by forty percent. The girl lived. The review board did not care that the girl lived. They cared that Evelyn had made the decision alone, in the dark, answering to no authority but her own certainty. She was censured. She chose the door before they could push her through it. She told herself she would never cross that line again. This was her daughter. This was three weeks old, five pounds, and silent. Evelyn opened the tablet on the side table with her free hand. The screen glowed with the latest vector simulation--a retinoic acid cascade she'd been refining in her off-hours, modeling it against axolotl regeneration data. The salamanders could regrow a severed limb in weeks: bone, nerve, muscle, skin, returned in full fidelity. Their secret was the blastema--a mass of dedifferentiated cells that formed at the wound site and rebuilt the structure from memory. Evelyn had been chasing a way to trigger that process in human tissue for three years. It had always been theoretical. Now it was personal. She scrolled through the payload architecture. Messenger RNA wrapped in lipid nanoparticles, targeted to the residual stem cells at the amputation plane. The sequence would instruct the cells to dedifferentiate, form a blastema, and begin rebuilding according to the body's own developmental map. It was elegant. It was untested. It was wildly, recklessly premature. She tapped the simulation's RUN button and watched the probability curves bloom across the screen. Sixty-two percent viability. Up from forty-one last week. Not enough for a clinical trial. Not enough for a journal. Not enough for anyone. Enough for a mother who had already proven she would cross the line when the math was right. "I'm going to fix you," she whispered into Nunnally's hair. The words were so quiet they barely disturbed the air. "I don't care what it costs." The baby's mouth moved once--a silent shape, round and open, as though she had heard and was trying to answer. Inside the left nub, the clicking continued. Patient. Expectant. Like something waiting to be let out.

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Fifty feet underground, the air tasted like a mistake someone had tried to sterilize. Colonel Marcus Hart stood in Gestation Bay 4 of Project Forge and watched the thing in the pod die. It was dying the way classified projects always died--by centimeters, behind glass, while someone with rank stood nearby and pretended it wasn't happening. Asset Zero floated in amber fluid, no larger than a man's fist. Its skin was translucent and veined with threads of pale light that flickered at uneven intervals, like a bulb on its way out. Gray flakes sloughed from its surface in lazy spirals, drifting through the fluid like ash from a fire no one had reported. The monitors scrolled in red: VIABILITY 43%. CELLULAR CASCADE ACCELERATING. REGRESSION CYCLE 7 OF 12. The bunker was buried under the Virginia hills, accessed through a road that ended at a locked gate in a forest where even the birdsong went thin. The official entrance was labeled WATER TREATMENT FACILITY--AUTHORIZED PERSONNEL. It had never processed a drop. The unofficial entrance was a cargo elevator disguised as a grain silo. Marcus used neither. He used the third entrance, the one that wasn't in any schematic, because the kind of man who got assigned to Forge was the kind of man who knew things that didn't exist. The air down here didn't smell like a hospital. It smelled of ozone, heated circuitry, and something else--faint, persistent, sweet in a way that made his back teeth itch. Like overripe fruit turning alcoholic. Like honey left in the sun until the sugar began to rot. It had been getting stronger for weeks. The ventilation techs couldn't find the source. Marcus could. It was coming from the pod. A young technician named Arnaud hovered at his elbow, talking too fast. "Regeneration markers are in freefall, sir. The axolotl-derived stem system keeps trying to rebuild, but there's no anchor. The tissue rewrites itself and then collapses--like it can't decide what it wants to be." "How long?" "If it drops below forty percent, we're looking at cascade failure within seventy-two hours. After that--" Arnaud made a small gesture, fingers opening, the universal shorthand for gone. Marcus didn't respond. He stood with his hands clasped behind his back, the posture they taught at West Point for moments when your face needed to say nothing. The military loved calm men. Calm men signed orders. Calm

men watched things dissolve in jars and called it progress. Project Forge's mandate had always been explained in the cleanest possible language: regenerative warfighters, self-healing assets, bioadaptive defense platforms. Marcus had read the classified briefs underneath the clean language. He knew what Asset Zero was actually for. The skin would secrete a resin--clear, beautiful, viscous as warm honey--that could harden on contact or remain tacky enough to coat any surface. The resin was a delivery system. A scratch from Asset Zero's fingernail could introduce an engineered pathogen that bloomed into cancer in fourteen days. A palm pressed to a pane of glass could turn the glass into a long-range vector, anyone who touched it absorbing the payload through their skin. A kiss could rewrite the target's hormone cascade, turning loyalty to compliance and compliance to worship. And beneath the resin: the second brain. A neural lobe grown adjacent to the primary cortex, dedicated entirely to synthesis. It could design new molecular payloads in real time--analyzing a target's biology, engineering a bespoke weapon, and secreting it through the skin in under a minute. A biological black box that thought in poisons. Marcus had justified it the way soldiers justified everything: by imagining the alternative. Shadow wars in countries whose names never made the news. Proxy conflicts where body bags were bad optics. Asset Zero was supposed to end fights before they started--one operative, one handshake, one quiet dissolution. No coffins. No flags. No hearings. But as he watched the gray flakes spiral in the amber fluid, the justification tasted different in his mouth. Sweeter. Thicker. Like the air in the vault. He turned from the pod and walked the corridor toward his office, boots silent on polished concrete. He passed Adjunct Lab 4, the one that had been stripped to the rivets and sealed. The glass partition still held a faint bloom of condensation on the inside, though the room had been empty for fourteen months. Captain Elias Reyes had sat in that room. Marcus had liked Reyes. Reyes smoked illegal Marlboros and quoted Kierkegaard and called the embryo "our little monster" with an affection that unsettled the review board. Give it a soul, Marc, Reyes had said once, leaning back in his chair with smoke curling past his eyes. Or it's just meat. The review board had

not appreciated this. The Purge Protocol triggered twelve hours later. It was designed to be clean--a heavy, clear mist delivered through the ventilation system, metabolizing organic tissue on contact. Marcus hadn't been present. He'd read the after-action report. It noted, with clinical efficiency, that the process took ninety-seven seconds and that the remains fit in a standard biohazard drum. The report did not note that Reyes's vocal cords dissolved first, or that the security camera captured eleven seconds of silent screaming before the face lost structural integrity. Marcus had watched the footage once. He had not slept the same way since. He reached his office--windowless, lit by a single strip of LED that turned everything the color of bad news--and sat at his desk. The red phone was already vibrating. It wasn't his service phone or his personal phone. It was the one that didn't ring, only pulsed, like a vein. He opened the message. Asset regression at 43%. 72-hour window before cellular cascade failure. Deliver viable enhancer or initiate termination protocol. No exceptions. Termination protocol. He read it the way you read a diagnosis. Twice, slowly, looking for the exit that wasn't there. Stand down meant audits. Audits meant scapegoats. Scapegoats meant the quiet thing that had happened to Reyes--the mist, the drum, the redacted file. Forge didn't retire loose ends. It dissolved them. He set the phone down. He rubbed the bridge of his nose until his vision blurred. And in the blur, he saw her--Nunnally. The nubs. The milky eyes. The clicking inside the skin that Evelyn didn't know he'd noticed. Cells that were already doing what the Asset could not: rebuilding. The Asset needed a compatible enhancer--human tissue already primed for regeneration, a biological key that could anchor the collapsing cascade. Not donor tissue. Not a culture dish. Something alive and specific and rare. Something that shared his blood. Marcus closed his eyes. The honey-rot sweetness thickened in his throat, and he realized, with a nausea he would never fully shake, that the solution and the sin were the same thing.

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He came home at dusk. The sedan's headlights swept across the colonial's front porch and caught the neighbor's holiday lights, red and green, still up

three days past New Year's. The gravel drive crunched under the tires. A normal sound. A safe sound. The kind of sound that belonged to a life he was about to steal from. Inside, the house smelled of reheated Thai food and baby powder. Evelyn was on the couch, Nunnally bundled against her shoulder, a tablet balanced on the armrest showing vector readouts that pulsed with soft color. She looked up when he entered. The exhaustion in her face had passed through tiredness into something architectural--built in, load-bearing, part of who she was now. "You're late," she said. "Budget review ran over." He kissed her temple. She tasted of salt. He kissed Nunnally's forehead. The baby's skin was warmer than it should have been--not fever-warm, but active-warm, like an engine idling beneath the surface. "She's responding," Evelyn said. She shifted the swaddle to show him the left nub. In the lamplight, the skin looked tighter than yesterday, stretched over a ridge that hadn't been there last week. Pink. Raw. Undeniable. "The latest vector is taking hold. Faster than the models predicted." Marcus stared at the ridge. His stomach did something complicated. Because he recognized it. Not from Evelyn's research. From the graphs on his desk at Forge. The same cellular signature. The same regenerative aggression. The exact biological frequency the Asset was starving for. He forced his voice steady. "That's incredible, Eve." She smiled--the first real smile he'd seen in weeks, bright and exhausted and terrifying in its hope--and leaned into him. "It's working, Marcus. It's actually working." He held them both and said nothing. The house creaked in its winter way, pipes adjusting, vents breathing. Through the living room window, snow began to fall--thick flakes drifting through the streetlight's cone, silent and indifferent. On the changing table in the nursery, a folded square of gauze sat beside the alcohol swabs. Two small rust-brown spots, each no larger than a teardrop, marked its center. From Evelyn's latest draw. Nunnally's blood. Marcus had noticed it when he'd carried the baby in. He'd noted its position the way a man notes an exit in a crowded room--automatically, without deciding to, filed under a heading he hadn't written yet.

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He waited until the house was asleep. Two in the morning. January cold pressing against the windowpanes like a hand testing for weakness. The furnace had cycled off and the air in the hallway carried the particular silence of a home where everyone is breathing and no one is awake. Evelyn's breathing, slow and shallow from the bedroom. Nunnally's breathing, faster, lighter, from the nursery at the end of the hall. The sequencer on the dresser exhaled its low mechanical hymn, a sound that had become so constant it had merged with the architecture of the house, indistinguishable from the walls. Marcus stood in the hallway in his socks. He had not turned on a light. The nursery door was open. It was always open--Evelyn insisted, needed to hear the monitors, needed the corridor of sound between her sleeping body and her daughter's. Marcus moved through it now, each step deliberate, weight on the balls of his feet, the muscle memory of a man who had been trained to enter rooms where the occupants should not know he was there. Moonlight came through the blinds in silver bars, falling across the bassinet like the ribs of a cage. The changing table stood against the far wall, its surface cluttered with the small debris of desperate medicine: syringes still in their sterile packaging, alcohol swabs, a portable centrifuge the size of a coffee maker, and the gauze. The gauze. Two rust-colored spots on white cotton. His daughter's blood, drawn twelve hours ago from a heel so small that the lancet had looked obscene against it. Evelyn had been careful--always careful, always precise, even when her hands shook--and she had set the gauze aside for disposal and then forgotten it in the fog of exhaustion. Marcus crossed the room. Six steps. Each one the length of a decision he was pretending not to make. He stood over the changing table and looked down at the gauze. In the moonlight the blood spots were almost black. They were so small. That was the obscenity of it--how little was needed. A few microliters. A stain no larger than a tear. Enough to anchor a cascade. Enough to wake a weapon. Enough to trade a daughter's cells for a monster's survival. His hand hovered. His fingers trembled. Not the gross shaking of fear--a fine,

high-frequency vibration, the precise tremor of a system under load. He pressed his thumb against his forefinger until the nail whitened. The tremor stopped. He didn't let himself notice that suppressing it required effort it shouldn't have. He could hear his own pulse now, thick in his ears, and underneath it--or maybe inside it--the ghost of the honey-rot smell from the bunker. Faint. Persistent. As if the sweetness had followed him home and was standing just behind his shoulder, breathing warm and patient against his neck. He thought of Evelyn in the next room. The trust in her body--turned toward the wall, arm outstretched across the mattress where he should be lying. She had married a soldier. She had understood compartmentalization, security clearances, the weight of things that couldn't be said. She had never imagined that the unsaid thing would be this. He thought of Reyes. The empty office. The biohazard drum. He thought: one drop. That's all. One drop and the cascade stabilizes and the project lives and I go home tomorrow and kiss my wife and hold my daughter and none of this has to become what it's becoming. The justification assembled itself in his chest with the smooth precision of a rifle being fieldstripped and reassembled. Patriotic: this protects the country. Paternal: this protects the family. Visionary: this is how the future is built, one small sacrifice at a time, by men willing to carry the weight. Each piece clicked into place. Each one tasted sweet. A darker thought moved behind the others, cold and fluid: perhaps this was how gods were born. Through small thefts. Through fathers who loved their daughters and stole from them anyway, because the alternative was disappearing into a drum. Marcus's fingers closed around the gauze. His foot caught the centrifuge cord. The machine shifted half an inch on the table--a small, dense sound, metal on laminate, absurdly loud in the dark. Marcus froze. His pulse detonated. In the bassinet, Nunnally stirred. Three seconds. He counted them because counting was what you did when your body wanted to run and your training wouldn't let it. The centrifuge settled. The house held its breath. It was lighter than he expected. Almost nothing. A whisper of cotton and dried blood that fit in his palm like a secret too small to confess. He slipped it into the pocket of his robe. Behind him, in the bassinet, Nunnally's face had turned toward him. Her

milky eyes, open in the dark, aimed at the space where his hand had been. And inside her left nub, the clicking stopped. Not faded. Not slowed. Stopped--the way a clock stops, all at once, in the middle of a tick. The silence it left was louder than the sound had been. Marcus froze. The gauze burned in his pocket like a coal. For three seconds--he counted them, because counting was what you did when your body wanted to run and your training wouldn't let it--he and his daughter existed in the same silence. Her eyes, sightless, pointed at him. His hand, guilty, pressed against his pocket. The moonlight held them both in its silver cage. Then Nunnally's mouth opened. Not the usual silent working, the formless shapes that Evelyn read as hunger or discomfort. This was a single shape. Round. Deliberate. A vowel pressed against the air without sound, but with intent so clear it landed in Marcus's chest like a fist. Ah. The nub twitched once. The clicking resumed--faster now, a rapid-fire articulation, as if whatever was inside had received new instructions. Marcus left the nursery without breathing. He closed the door to three inches, exactly as Evelyn kept it, and stood in the hallway with his hand over his pocket, pressing the gauze against his thigh as though pressure could undo what he'd done. The house settled around him. Cold and quiet and complicit.

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He drove to Forge before dawn. The roads were empty, glazed with frost that turned the headlights into smears. The sedan's heater struggled against a cold that seemed to come from inside the car. Marcus drove with one hand. The other rested on the gauze in his coat pocket, thumb moving over the dried blood spots in slow circles, the way a man fingers a rosary when the prayer has stopped being voluntary. The descent into the bunker took ninety seconds. Retinal scan, voice print, biometric. The elevator cage dropped through cold air that grew warmer and sweeter as he descended, the honey-rot thickening until he could taste it on the roof of his mouth--not unpleasant, not yet, just present, the way a new flavor is present before you decide whether you like it. Gestation Bay 4. Four in the morning. The pod glowed amber in the darkened vault. Asset Zero was worse. The fluid had

clouded overnight, gray with cellular debris. The embryo had drawn inward, compacting, a knot of failing tissue that pulsed at the wrong rhythm--too slow, too irregular, the heartbeat of something forgetting how to live. Marcus donned nitrile gloves. He moved to the infusion console with the economy of a man who has decided to stop thinking. He unwrapped the gauze. He scraped the dried blood into the saline reservoir with a sterile blade, watching the rust-brown flakes dissolve into pale pink. He primed the infusion line. The solution traveled through clear tubing, snaking toward the pod, catching the amber light like a vein of diluted sunset. He pressed INITIATE. The fluid entered the pod through a port at the base. For a long moment--thirty seconds, forty--nothing changed. The monitors continued their scrolling elegy. The gray flakes continued their drift. The embryo continued its slow contraction. Marcus stared through the plexiglass and felt the specific despair of a man who has committed an unforgivable act for nothing. Then the fluid moved. Not drift. Not current. The amber solution surrounding the embryo began to rotate--slowly at first, then with gathering urgency, as though something at the center had begun to pull. The gray flakes reversed course, spiraling inward, reabsorbed into tissue that had been shedding them for weeks. The monitors shrieked. INTEGRITY SURGE. CELLULAR DENSITY SHIFTING. VIABILITY 51%. 58%. 67%. The embryo uncurled. It happened in stages, each one punctuated by a sound Marcus would hear in his dreams for the rest of his life. The skin split along the dorsal line--a wet, precise unzipping, seam opening from skull to tailbone--and from the split, new tissue erupted. Bone, threading through translucent flesh like frost forming on glass. Muscle, layering in red ribbons. A torso elongating, limbs unfurling, fingers spreading. At the base of the skull, a second mass swelled--the neural lobe, the weapons brain, bulging behind the brainstem with the obscene confidence of a tumor that knew it was wanted. The growth was industrial. Mechanical in its speed, biological in its wetness. The sound of it filled the vault--a sustained, tearing, layered noise, like fabric ripping underwater. In under four minutes, the thing in the pod was no longer an embryo. It was a boy. Pale and hairless and floating in fluid that had turned from amber to

the color of old gold. His body was lean, proportioned like a teenager's, though he had been tissue four minutes ago. His eyes were closed. His chest rose and fell in the fluid with the slow rhythm of something that had been alive much longer than it had. Along his neck, small translucent glands had formed in neat rows, already glistening with a clear secretion that caught the light like dew. The resin glands. Functional. Full. The honey-rot smell hit Marcus like a wall. It was no longer faint. It was lush, overwhelming, sweet enough to coat the back of his throat, and underneath the sweetness--so far underneath you had to be paying attention--the crisp electric bite of ozone. Like standing too close to a transformer. Like the air before lightning. The boy opened his eyes. They were fractured blue, shot through with veins of electric azure that pulsed once, twice, like a signal finding its frequency. They locked onto Marcus through the plexiglass with a focus that was not newborn. Not confused. Not searching. The eyes of something that had been waiting for exactly this. The boy pressed his palm against the glass. Fingers splayed wide, new and pale and perfect. And Marcus felt it. A hook behind his ribs. Not pain--deeper, more structural, as if a tendon he hadn't known existed had been seized and pulled taut. His hand rose without his permission and pressed against the glass opposite the boy's palm. The word arrived in his skull the way a migraine arrives--sudden, total, filling every available space. Father. It wasn't sound. It wasn't language. It was a pressure that carried meaning, the way a shockwave carries heat. Marcus's vision blurred. His mouth flooded with the taste of honey and rot and copper and somewhere, underneath it all, the mineral salt of a baby's skin. Nunnally's skin. Because the bridge was not one-way.

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Thirty-seven miles away, in the silver-barred dark of the nursery, Nunnally Hart opened her mouth. She did not cry. She had never cried. But the clicking inside her left nub accelerated into something new--a rapid, rhythmic percussion, bone-on-bone-on-something-that-was-not-yet-bone, as if the limb she didn't have was trying to build itself in real time. Her

milky eyes stared at the ceiling. For the first time since birth, something behind them shifted--not sight, not yet, but a change in the quality of the blankness, like the difference between a television that is off and a television that is on but receiving no signal. The sequencer on the dresser chimed a reading it had never produced. Evelyn's tablet, on the nightstand in the next room, lit up with an alert she would find in the morning and stare at for a long time: a spike in Nunnally's cellular activity so extreme that the software flagged it as a sensor malfunction. It was not a malfunction. It was an answer. Thirty-seven miles south, in a bunker that didn't exist, a boy made of her blood pressed his hand to the glass and called a stranger Father. And in the nursery that smelled of soap and alcohol and the faintest trace of something sweet, a baby girl made of the same blood felt the call land in her body like a tuning fork struck in an adjacent room--not heard, but felt. In the teeth. In the bones. In the space where her arms should have been. The clicking grew louder. Evelyn slept through it. She would sleep through many things in the weeks to come. The house breathed around them both--vents sighing, pipes ticking, the old colonial settling into its foundations the way it had for sixty years. But the breath was different now. There was a frequency in it that had not been there before. A low hum, below the threshold of hearing, that made the fillings in the walls vibrate at intervals too regular to be random. In the basement, the circuit breaker tripped and reset itself. In the nursery, Nunnally's right nub twitched. And the clicking, steady now, patient now, continued through the dark--a conversation in a language that had no words yet, between a daughter and a brother she had never met, across a bridge their father had built from stolen blood. The fracture had begun.

SYNAPSE 01

THE CALCULUS OF ZERO

\[SOURCE: PROJECT FORGE / INTERNAL MEMORANDUM / EYES ONLY\]

FROM: Gen. H. Vance, DARPA Oversight

TO: Col. Marcus Hart, Forge Operations Lead

DATE: 2026-01-03

CLASSIFICATION: UMBRA / NOFORN / ORCON

RE: Asset Zero -- Viability Status and Contingency

Colonel,

Asset Zero viability index: 43.2%. Decline of 12.7% over 96 hours. Cascade failure projected within 72 hours absent compatible biological enhancer.

Enhancer requirements unchanged. Living human tissue with active regenerative markers compatible with axolotl-derived architecture. Standard donor tissue rejected across 14 trials. The cascade requires a biological anchor: tissue that has survived a regenerative event and can serve as stabilization template.

Personnel are reminded that Termination Protocol (ref: FORGE-TP-7) activates upon cascade failure. All associated personnel, documentation, and biological materials will be processed per standard containment. Reference: Case File 11-A (Capt. Reyes, E.).

No exceptions. No appeals.

72-hour extension granted. This extension is final.

Howard

\[ADDENDUM -- Col. Hart's copy, lower margin, pencil:\]

What does it want to be?

\[SECOND ADDENDUM -- Arnaud's copy, ballpoint, cramped:\]

It was humming today. Not from the speakers. From the glass. I put my hand on the pod and felt it in my fingers like a phone vibrating. Nobody else noticed or maybe nobody wanted to. I didn't log it. I keep not logging things.

CHAPTER TWO

Whispers in the Flesh

Evelyn woke to an alert she didn't understand. The tablet on the nightstand was pulsing amber, the screen filled with a readout that looked like a seismograph during an earthquake. Nunnally's cellular activity--baseline metabolic rate, mitotic index, the regenerative markers Evelyn had been tracking with the obsessive precision of a woman who had replaced sleep with data--had spiked at 4:11 a.m. A single vertical line, sharp as a scream, that dwarfed every reading she'd taken in three weeks of monitoring. The software had flagged it as a sensor malfunction. Evelyn sat on the edge of the bed, hair unwashed, wearing the same T-shirt she'd slept in for two days, and stared at the spike until the screen dimmed. It was not a malfunction. She knew that the way she knew her own heartbeat--not through evidence but through the particular dread of a scientist who has seen data that shouldn't exist. The house was quiet. Too quiet. Marcus's side of the bed was empty but still warm, the sheets creased in the shape of a body that had left recently. His keys were gone from the bowl on the dresser. His coat was gone from the hook by the door. She noted these absences the way she'd learned to note everything lately: automatically, without alarm, cataloged in the growing file of things about her husband that didn't quite fit. She went to the nursery. Nunnally was awake. That was the first strangeness. The baby almost never woke before Evelyn came in--she existed in a world without light or sound, and her sleep-wake cycle

had become a kind of tide, governed by internal rhythms that had nothing to do with dawn. But this morning her milky eyes were open, aimed at the ceiling, and her body was radiating heat through the swaddle like a stone that had been sitting in sunlight. Evelyn lifted her and felt it immediately. The baby was heavier. Not by much--ounces, maybe--but Evelyn had held this body every day for three weeks, and her arms were calibrated to its weight the way a jeweler's hands are calibrated to grams. Something had been added. She unwrapped the swaddle. The left nub had changed overnight. The ridge she'd shown Marcus the evening before--the pink, raw line of new cartilage--had thickened. It was no longer a suggestion. It was a declaration. The skin had stretched and thinned over something structural beneath it, something with dimension, with intent. Evelyn could see the shadows of new vasculature branching beneath the translucent surface--tiny rivers of blood feeding territory that hadn't existed twelve hours ago. Her breath caught. She pressed her thumb gently against the ridge. It was firm. Warm. It pressed back. The clicking inside the nub was louder now. Not the tentative bone-on-bone she'd been telling herself was settling cartilage. This was purposeful. Rhythmic. A construction sound--small machines at work inside her daughter's body, building something with a confidence that Evelyn's own research could not explain. Because the timeline was wrong. Evelyn's vector was good. She knew it was good. But it was designed for incremental progress--millimeters of tissue over weeks, guided by careful dosing and constant monitoring. What she was looking at now was not incremental. It was aggressive. As if something had turbocharged the process overnight, flooding Nunnally's cells with a regenerative urgency that went beyond anything the vector alone could produce. She carried the baby to the dining room table--her other battlefield, the one covered in petri dishes and vials and the portable sequencer that never stopped humming--and began running diagnostics. Blood draw from the heel, capillary tube, centrifuge spinning while she rocked Nunnally with one arm and read numbers with the other. The numbers didn't make sense. Mitotic rate tripled. Blastema density off the chart. Growth factors she hadn't introduced showing up in concentrations that shouldn't be possible without

an external catalyst. Something was feeding the process. Something that wasn't her. Evelyn stared at the readouts and felt two things collide in her chest: the thrill of a scientist watching the impossible happen, and the terror of a mother realizing she was not the only force acting on her child's body. She chose the thrill. She chose it the way you choose a door in a burning building--not because you know it's safe, but because the alternative is standing still. "All right," she said to Nunnally, her voice steadier than her hands. "If you're ready, I'm ready." She reached for the syringe.

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The vector was clear as water and as precise as a sentence. Evelyn had spent eleven nights refining it--stripping redundancies, tightening the messenger payload, adjusting the lipid envelope until the nanoparticles would find their targets with the accuracy of heat-seeking rounds. She had modeled it against every piece of axolotl regeneration data in the public literature and several pieces that weren't public at all, borrowed from old files her former colleague Dr. Lena Voss had left behind before her death. The sequence didn't just repair. It insisted. She swabbed the left nub with alcohol. Nunnally's skin was so thin here that Evelyn could see the shadow of the new structure beneath it--a dark shape, branching, like a tree seen through fog. She hesitated. The dosage she'd prepared was aggressive--forty percent above the model's safe ceiling, a ceiling she had set herself, carefully, conservatively, the way she'd been taught. The way she'd promised herself she would always work, after Hopkins. The math justified the risk. It always did, if you were smart enough and desperate enough to build the right equation. She slid the needle in. The baby didn't flinch. She had never flinched from needles. Evelyn sometimes wondered if Nunnally's damaged nerves were a mercy--the body shielding itself from the full cost of what was being done to it. She depressed the plunger. Slow. Steady. A controlled introduction, not a flood. Then she waited. The sequencer hummed. The house was still. Through the dining room windows, January light fell in pale shafts across the table, catching the edges of the vials and throwing tiny rainbows across the wall--absurdly beautiful in a room that

smelled of antiseptic and old takeout. Thirty seconds. Nothing. Sixty seconds. Evelyn's fingers found Nunnally's pulse at the wrist--fast, steady, the engine running hot. Ninety seconds. Then a tremor passed through the nub. Not a twitch--a ripple, originating deep, radiating outward through the tissue like a stone dropped into still water. The ridge of cartilage she'd been monitoring shifted. Visibly. The skin stretched, went white at the edges, and then-- Schick. The sound was small and precise and wet. Like a seam opening along a line that had been scored in advance. A split appeared at the tip of the nub--clean, bloodless for one heartbeat, then welling with a single bead of bright red that caught the morning light and held it like a jewel. From the split, something pushed outward. Cartilage first. Pink and raw and glistening, emerging with the slow inevitability of a plant breaking through soil. It didn't look like bone. It looked like the idea of bone--a sketch made of living tissue, translucent enough that Evelyn could see the nerve filaments threading through it in real time, firing in tiny, silent sparks, like bioluminescence in deep ocean. Then the cartilage hardened. She watched it happen--watched the tissue shift from gel to solid in a gradient that moved from the base outward, opaque white chasing translucent pink the way ice forms across the surface of a lake. Proto-bone. Real bone. Her daughter's body remembering a shape it had never been allowed to take and building it now with a furious, delicate precision that made Evelyn's hands shake and her vision blur. The bud lengthened. Skin stretched to follow, impossibly elastic, resealing behind the growth as if it had done this a thousand times. Blood vessels raced to keep up--she could see them branching in real time, red threads chasing the new tissue like vines following sunlight. Muscle fibers layered themselves in thin red ribbons, contracting experimentally, testing tension. A finger. It was unmistakably a finger. Small and new and glistening with the fluid of its own arrival. It extended from the bud at an angle that looked, for one impossible second, like a hand reaching out of a grave. Then it flexed. The flex was instinctive--not directed, not purposeful, just a new nerve firing for the first time and discovering that it was connected to something that could move. The finger curled inward, trembled, uncurled. Curled again. Seeking.

Evelyn's sob broke free before she could stop it--a sound that was part triumph and part grief and part raw animal relief, the sound of a woman who had spent three weeks holding a broken thing and had just felt it begin to mend in her hands. She held Nunnally closer. The baby's milky eyes were open, and the veils had thinned--not cleared, not yet, but thinned, the way frost thins on a windshield when the defroster kicks in. Behind the white, the faintest ghost of blue. Iris, emerging. Color returning to a world that had been colorless. The new finger found Evelyn's thumb. Touched it. Wrapped around it with the slow, testing grip of a creature learning what it means to hold on. Evelyn wept. She wept without sound, the way she'd trained herself to weep in the NICU when the nurses were watching--tears only, no noise, because noise was weakness and weakness was a luxury she could not afford. The tears fell on Nunnally's forehead and the baby's mouth made that silent shape again--the round, deliberate vowel, pressed against the air like a word trying to be born. For one perfect, uncontaminated moment, the world was nothing but a mother and a daughter and a finger that had not existed five minutes ago, curling around a thumb, holding on. Evelyn didn't notice the smell. It was faint. Background. A sweetness in the air that could have been anything--the takeout containers in the trash, the dregs of coffee on the counter, the chemical warmth of the sequencer running hot. She breathed it in without registering it, the way you breathe the first trace of smoke before your brain decides it's fire. By the time she noticed it, it would be too late. But that was tomorrow's problem. Right now, there was only the finger, and the grip, and the sound of clicking inside the nub accelerating into a hum that was almost--almost--music.

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Thirty-seven miles south, the thing that had been Asset Zero breathed on its own for the first time. The pod had been drained at 0600. The amber fluid sluiced into reclamation tanks, leaving the boy--it was difficult not to call it a boy now, though every protocol document still referred to it as "the Asset"--lying on the curved glass floor of the cylinder, pale and still and steaming faintly in the cold vault air. His eyes were closed. His chest rose

and fell. Along his neck, the translucent glands pulsed in slow rhythm, secreting a thin film that caught the overhead lights and turned them soft gold. The vault smelled like a greenhouse in August. Warm. Alive. Wrong. A security detail ringed the pod at ten-meter intervals, rifles angled at a thing that looked like a sleeping teenager and registered on their thermal scopes as 104.8 degrees Fahrenheit. Too hot for human. Too still for threat. Too new for anyone to have a protocol for. Colonel Hart had left instructions: no direct contact. Observation only. Core samples at arm's length. Do not speak to the Asset. Do not respond if the Asset speaks. Arnaud was running the early diagnostics when the morning rotation arrived. He handed the clipboard to Dr. Maren Seo with the particular relief of a man who had been alone with something he didn't want to be alone with. "Core temp 104.8. Neural activity off the scale--every region lit simultaneously. I flagged it as anomalous but it's been sustained for two hours." He paused. "He hasn't moved. But I don't think he's sleeping." Maren took the clipboard without comment. She was thirty-one, third-year Forge rotation, the kind of scientist who had gotten into military biotech because the private sector wouldn't fund her real interests: liminal biology, the threshold states between growth and collapse where cells made decisions that looked, if you squinted, like choices. She wore her hair tied back so tight it pulled at her temples, and she carried her coffee in a steel thermos because the ceramic mugs in the break room always smelled faintly of the nutrient baths. She approached the pod with her tablet and her training and the particular calm of a woman who had spent two years cataloging failures in this vault and had stopped expecting anything that required awe. She pressed her badge to the access panel. The pod's outer shell retracted in quadrants, exposing the inner glass. The smell hit her first--thick, sweet, layered, like walking into a room where someone had been baking bread and burning candles simultaneously. She noted it on her tablet without comment. Her job was baselines, not poetry. She ran the handheld scanner along the Asset's torso at the prescribed distance: thirty centimeters, no closer. Core temperature, dermal conductivity, respiratory rate. The numbers were extraordinary and she logged them with steady

hands. Heart rate 42--bradycardic by human standards, but the Asset's cardiovascular architecture wasn't human. Oxygen saturation 99.8 percent. Neural activity-- She paused. Looked at the readout. Looked again. Neural activity was off the scale. Not elevated. Not spiking. Sustained. Every region lit simultaneously, a level of parallel processing that in a human brain would indicate a grand mal seizure. In the Asset, it looked like thinking. All of it, all at once, about everything. She noted it. Moved on. The scan swept down to the limbs, the hands, the resin glands at the neck-- The Asset opened his eyes. There was no transition. No flutter, no drowsy surfacing. One moment closed, the next open. Fractured blue, veined with light, focused on her face with a clarity that felt less like sight and more like being read. Maren's hand stopped moving. The scanner hung in the air between them. Protocol was explicit: do not respond. She knew this. She had signed the page. She stared at the readout on her tablet and tried to pretend the eyes were not on her. But the warmth shifted. It was subtle--not a temperature change on the scanner, not something the instruments would catch. It was a change in quality. The air between Maren and the glass became denser, closer, the way air changes in a small room when someone steps nearer. A pressure that wasn't physical. A proximity that had nothing to do with distance. Her breath fogged the glass, and in the fog, she saw his hand move. Slow. Not toward her. Toward the glass itself. Palm flat. Fingers open. She thought, absurdly: he's lonely. The thought was not hers. She knew that with the same certainty she knew her own name. It had arrived in her mind fully formed, wearing her voice, using her syntax, indistinguishable from her own thinking except for the fact that she had not been thinking it until she was. She stepped back. The air thinned. The warmth receded. The Asset's eyes closed, slow as a door being pulled shut by someone who wanted you to see it close. Maren logged the rest of her readings in the corridor, leaning against the wall with her thermos pressed to her chest, her hands steady and her heart doing something her training had no name for. She did not mention the thought in her report. She filed it under the growing category of things about Forge that she would deal with later. Later never came. But that's a different chapter.

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Marcus came home at seven. Evelyn met him at the door holding Nunnally like a trophy. "Look," she said. Just the one word, but it carried the weight of every sleepless night and every failed simulation and every moment she had spent in the NICU whispering promises into hair that smelled of hospital soap. She held up the baby's left arm. The bud had progressed since morning. The single finger had been joined by the ghost of a second, a translucent ridge emerging from the blastema with the slow confidence of a tide that knows exactly where it's going. The skin had sealed over the original split. The clicking had settled into a steady rhythm, quick and even, like a heartbeat's apprentice learning the trade. Marcus stood in the doorway with his coat still on and snow melting in his hair and looked at his daughter's hand and said nothing for a long time. He was thinking about a boy in a pod. A boy with the same regenerative signature. A boy who had opened his eyes six hours ago and pressed his palm to glass and spoken a word directly into the center of Marcus's skull. He was thinking about how the finger growing on Nunnally's arm looked exactly like the fingers that had splayed against the plexiglass. He was thinking: what have I connected. "Marcus?" Evelyn's smile faltered. "What's wrong? This is good. This is--this is everything." He blinked. He manufactured a smile that used all the right muscles and none of the right feelings. "It's incredible," he said. "She's incredible. You're incredible." He took the baby. Held her against his chest. Nunnally's new finger--wet, pink, impossibly delicate--curled against his collar and gripped the fabric with a strength that startled him. And he felt it again. The hook. Fainter than in the vault, but unmistakable--a tug behind his ribs, a tightening of something that connected his body to a place thirty-seven miles south, where a boy he had built from his daughter's blood was lying in a drained pod, eyes closed, glands pulsing, learning what his own hands could do. The baby's grip tightened. Marcus looked down at the finger on his collar. It was so small. So new. So much like the fingers he'd seen through the glass. Evelyn was already back at the dining table, pulling up readouts, talking fast--dosing schedules, growth projections, the

possibility that full limb regeneration could be achieved within weeks, not months. Her voice was bright and alive in a way it hadn't been since before the delivery. Hope had returned to the house like electricity to a dead circuit, buzzing through every room, making the lights feel warmer and the walls feel closer. Marcus listened. He nodded. He held the baby. And somewhere beneath the baby powder and the reheated food and the medicinal bite of alcohol swabs, he caught it--faint as a rumor, sweet as a lie--the smell. His smell. The one that had followed him out of the bunker and into the car and through the door and into the house where his wife was celebrating a miracle that was half his theft. Nunnally's milky eyes were open. The fog in them had thinned further--he could see the blue now, a vein of color emerging from the white like a crack in ice. She was looking at him. Not seeing--not yet--but oriented. Aimed. Her mouth opened. The silent shape. Ah. The same vowel. The same intent. This time, Marcus heard something underneath it--a pressure, not from Nunnally's throat but from somewhere deeper, resonating through the shared architecture of blood and theft: a second voice, layered beneath hers, harmonizing in a key that human vocal cords could not produce. Not a word. Not yet. Just presence. Something behind his daughter's eyes that had not been there yesterday, looking out through her the way a tenant looks out through a window in a building they didn't build. Marcus held the baby closer and told himself it was love he was feeling. Love, and nothing else. The house breathed. The sequencer hummed. Outside, the snow continued to fall, covering everything in white, burying the evidence of every footprint, every tire track, every path that led from this house to the place where the fracture had begun. In the basement, the circuit breaker tripped and reset itself for the second time in twelve hours. The first had been at 4:11 a.m., when the spike hit Nunnally's readings. The second was now, at 7:14 p.m., the moment Marcus crossed the threshold with the smell still in his coat. Both events lasted exactly 1.86 seconds--the propagation time for a signal traveling at the speed of nerve conduction across a distance of thirty-seven miles. Nobody noticed. Nobody connected the times.

CHAPTER THREE

The Intern

The girl who came to the door was not what Evelyn expected. The application had been impressive--unnervingly so for a sixteen-year-old. Perfect scores in molecular biology and organic chemistry from the accelerated program at Thomas Jefferson. A recommendation letter from the department chair that used the word "extraordinary" three times without apparent embarrassment. A personal statement so precisely written it read less like a teenager's college supplement and more like a grant proposal from someone who had already been rejected once and was not going to make the same mistakes. But the girl standing on the porch at nine in the morning on January seventh, wearing a coat too thin for the weather and holding a messenger bag against her hip like a shield, did not look extraordinary. She looked careful. She looked like someone who had learned to take up as little space as possible and had gotten very good at it. "Elara Voss?" "Dr. Hart. Thank you for the opportunity." The voice was steady. The eyes were not. They moved--quick, cataloging--across the doorframe, the foyer, the coat hooks, the line of shoes by the mat. Not nervous. Systematic. The way Evelyn herself scanned a new dataset: looking for the shape of what she was about to enter. Evelyn stepped aside. "Come in. It's freezing." Elara crossed the threshold. She stopped. It was barely a pause--less than a second, a hitch in her stride that could have been a foot catching on the mat or an adjustment to the warmth of the house after

the January air. But something happened in that moment, something that registered in the girl's body before it reached her face. Her shoulders dropped. Not relaxed--released, the way a fist unclenches when the thing it was bracing against doesn't come. Elara Voss had lived with a noise in her body for five years. Not a sound she could describe to a doctor, because she had tried, and the doctors had looked at her the way doctors look at teenagers who have silver scars on their wrists--with a careful, practiced kindness that assumes the problem is psychological and the prescription is patience. The noise was deeper than hearing. It lived in the tissue itself: a low, directionless static, like a television tuned to a dead channel, broadcasting from inside her bones. Some days it was a whisper. Some days it was a roar. It had been with her since the day in Lab 4 when the mist had touched her skin and the world had caught fire and then gone very, very quiet. She had never told anyone what the noise actually felt like, because the closest comparison was one no sixteen-year-old could make without being hospitalized: it felt like homesickness for a place she had never been. Standing in the foyer of the Hart residence, the noise stopped. Not faded. Not dimmed. Stopped--the way a headache stops, all at once, leaving behind a silence so total it has its own weight. The static in her bones went flat. The low, grinding ache that she had carried in her wrists, her jaw, the base of her skull since she was eleven years old simply ceased, as though someone had found the frequency she was tuned to and matched it. Elara stood very still and breathed. The house smelled of coffee and antiseptic and baby powder and something else--faint, sweet, underneath everything, like a note in a chord you only hear if you stop listening for the melody. She breathed it in and felt her pulse slow to a rhythm she did not recognize as her own. "Are you all right?" Evelyn was watching her. "Fine." Elara adjusted the bag on her shoulder. "Sorry. Long bus ride." She followed Evelyn into the house and did not look back at the door.

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The dining room had been converted into a laboratory with the particular desperation of someone who could not wait for proper equipment. Evelyn's

setup sprawled across the oak table like the aftermath of a very organized explosion: petri dishes in numbered rows, a portable centrifuge trailing cables to a power strip, vials of clear solution arranged by date in a plastic rack, a sequencer the size of a hardcover novel humming steadily on a folded towel. Stacks of printouts covered one end of the table--graphs, chromatography readouts, molecular models annotated in Evelyn's small, aggressive handwriting. A half-eaten granola bar sat on top of a paper titled "Retinoic Acid Cascade Modeling: Axolotl-Derived Blastema Induction in Mammalian Tissue." "I should warn you," Evelyn said, clearing a chair by moving a box of syringes to the floor, "this isn't a normal internship. I'm not running a structured program. I need someone who can monitor equipment, log data, and not ask questions about why I'm doing this at my kitchen table instead of at Apex." "I don't need structure," Elara said. She was already looking at the printouts, head tilted, reading upside down. "Is that a Voss-modified regeneration pathway?" Evelyn went still. "You know that name?" "It's in the literature. Dr. Lena Voss published two papers on axolotl limb regeneration before her work was classified. The lipid envelope design in your vector--" She pointed at a molecular diagram without touching it. "That's her architecture. You modified the payload, but the delivery system is hers." Evelyn stared at the girl for a long moment. The application had not mentioned a connection to Lena Voss. The recommendation letter had not mentioned it. The personal statement, with its precise, careful sentences, had not mentioned it. "How do you know Lena Voss's work?" Elara's hands were in her lap. Her sleeves were pulled down to her knuckles, the way they always were--a habit so old it had become architecture, the body building walls around the places it needed to protect. "She published. I read." It was not a lie. It was a wall shaped like the truth, and Evelyn recognized it because she had built similar walls herself--the kind a scientist constructs when the real answer involves a story she is not ready to tell. Evelyn let it go. She needed help more than she needed answers. "The sequencer needs recalibrating every four hours. The centrifuge overheats if you run it past ninety minutes. And the baby--" A sound from the next room. Not a cry--Nunnally never cried. A shifting, a

rustle of fabric, and beneath it, the clicking. Steady. Patient. The sound that Evelyn had stopped hearing because it had become the house's heartbeat. Elara heard it. Her chin lifted. Her nostrils flared, the way an animal's do when it catches a scent it recognizes but cannot name. The color left her face, and then returned, and then left again--a tide of blood responding to something that had nothing to do with the temperature of the room. Beneath the sleeves, against the silver lines on her wrists, her skin flushed pink. She did not know why. She did not look down. But her hands, buried in her lap, opened--slowly, unconsciously--palms turning upward, as if receiving something. "That's Nunnally," Evelyn said. "My daughter. She's in the living room. Come meet her."

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The baby was smaller than Elara expected. Nunnally lay in a bassinet by the window, swaddled in white cotton, bathed in the thin January light that came through the blinds in pale horizontal bars. Her milky eyes were open--they were almost always open, Evelyn had explained, because the visual cortex had never received the signal to coordinate a sleep cycle with sight--and her mouth moved in the small, silent shapes that Elara would come to know as well as her own breathing. She was three weeks and four days old. Two fingers now extended from the left nub--pink, raw, glistening with the moisture of new skin--curling and uncurling in slow, experimental flexions. The right nub showed the first ridge of a bud, a raised line beneath the skin that pulsed faintly when the light hit it at the right angle. The clicking was louder here. Not the house's ambient percussion--this was the source. Close. Intimate. Coming from inside the baby's body with a rhythm that Elara felt in her teeth. She knew this sound. She did not know that she knew it--not consciously, not in the part of her brain that could form sentences and offer explanations. But somewhere deeper, in the tissue itself, in the silver-scarred nerves of her wrists, a recognition fired. The clicking was a key turning in a lock she had not known was there. The sound was five years old. It was the last sound she had heard before the mist, before the screaming that wasn't screaming, before the world went white and then

went wrong. Schick. The memory surfaced like a body from deep water--not whole, not clear, just a shape. Glass. A hand pressed against glass. The sound of something growing where it shouldn't. Elara's vision tunneled. For one second the dining room disappeared and she was eleven years old, standing in an observation gallery, watching her mother's hand fuse to a window while something bloomed from her open mouth-- "Would you like to hold her?" Evelyn's voice pulled her back. The dining room returned. The light. The vials. The granola bar. "Yes," Elara said. Her voice didn't shake. She had spent five years learning how to keep her voice from shaking, and the skill was so practiced now that it worked even when the rest of her was falling. Evelyn lifted Nunnally from the bassinet and placed her in Elara's arms. The baby weighed almost nothing. Five pounds and change, distributed across a body that was more potential than presence--a sketch of a person, still being drawn. Elara cradled her the way she'd been taught in the CPR module at Jefferson: forearm as cradle, palm supporting the skull, elbow tucked to provide a shelf. Textbook. Controlled. Correct. But the moment Nunnally's body settled against her chest, something happened that was not in any textbook. The clicking changed. It had been steady--a metronome, even and patient, the same rhythm Elara had been hearing since she walked in. Now it shifted. Slowed. Not weaker--deeper. The percussive edges smoothed, and the gaps between clicks filled with something that was not quite sound, not quite silence. A harmonic. A resonance. As if the clicking had been searching for a frequency to lock onto and had just found it. Nunnally's milky eyes turned. Not toward Evelyn. Not toward the window or the light. Toward Elara. The baby's head moved on its weak neck--a deliberate, effortful rotation that Evelyn had never seen directed at anyone other than herself--and those veiled eyes aimed at Elara's face with a focus that was not infant. Not random. Oriented. Aimed. Evelyn watched from the doorway and felt something she could not name. It was not jealousy, though it wore jealousy's clothes. It was the shock of a mother who has been her child's entire world discovering that the world has just expanded without her permission. "She doesn't usually do that," Evelyn said quietly. Elara didn't answer. She was

looking at the baby's face, at the mouth making its silent shapes, and she was feeling something she had no framework for: the ache in her wrists--the constant, grinding, five-year ache--was not just quiet now. It was gone. Replaced by a warmth that started at the scars and spread through her forearms, her chest, the base of her skull, like standing in front of a fire after years of cold. Nunnally's new fingers--two on the left hand, pink and fragile and impossibly alive--reached up and touched Elara's collarbone. The touch was feather-light. The fingers were warm and slightly wet and they found the hollow of Elara's throat and rested there as if they had done this before. Elara closed her eyes. Behind the silver scars, deep in the tissue where the resin had buried its dormant code five years ago, something answered. Not a sound. Not a thought. A frequency--matching, aligning, the way two tuning forks will harmonize when one is struck and the other is close enough to listen. Nunnally's mouth opened. Ah. The silent vowel. But this time it was not aimed at the ceiling or the dark or the space where her mother's face had been. It was aimed at Elara. And Elara, who had not been held or touched or needed by another human being in any way that mattered since she was eleven years old, felt the sound--soundless as it was--land in the center of her chest like a hand pressing flat against her sternum and saying: She opened her eyes. The baby was still looking at her. "I think she likes you," Evelyn said. Elara looked up. Her face was composed. Her eyes were dry. Her voice was steady when she spoke. "What time should I come tomorrow?"

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She should have left at five. Evelyn had said five. The internship was part-time--school came first, the department chair had been explicit--and the bus back to Falls Church ran on the hour. Elara was still there at seven when Marcus came through the door. She had spent the afternoon calibrating the sequencer, logging Nunnally's readings at thirty-minute intervals, and organizing the printouts into a filing system that Evelyn had been too exhausted to maintain. She worked the way she did everything: quietly, precisely, without asking for permission or praise. When Evelyn

had fallen asleep on the couch with the baby on her chest--a forty-minute nap that she had not intended and would not remember--Elara had continued working, alone in the dining room, listening to the clicking through the wall and feeling the silence in her bones like a gift she hadn't earned. The front door opened. Cold air, road salt, the creak of winter hinges. Marcus entered the way a man enters his own home when he has forgotten that someone new is inside it: coat half-off, keys tossed toward the bowl (they missed; they landed on the floor), the sigh of a body releasing the posture it had held all day. Then he saw Elara. The posture returned. It was subtle--a straightening, a resettlement of weight--but Elara caught it because catching shifts in adult behavior had been a survival skill since she was eleven. His face assembled itself into the particular expression of a man who is professionally trained to reveal nothing: pleasant, neutral, a mask built from the absence of expression rather than the presence of one. "You must be the intern." "Elara Voss. Sir." "Marcus." He hung his coat by the door. "How was the first day?" "Productive." The word hung in the air between them like a test. Marcus looked at her for a moment longer than necessary--not suspicious, not threatening, but assessing, the way an officer assesses a new variable in an operational environment--and then turned to the living room, where Evelyn was waking up with the baby. Elara stood at the dining table and cataloged what she had noticed: The coat. It carried a smell. Not the road salt, not the leather, not the aftershave that had faded hours ago. Underneath all of those, faint as a thumbprint on clean glass: sweetness. The same sweetness that lived in the Hart house, but concentrated, denser, as if Marcus had been somewhere the smell was not a trace but a presence. His hands. He had picked up Nunnally when Evelyn offered her, and he had held her correctly--steady, supportive, the posture of a father who loved his daughter--but his eyes had not gone to the nub. They had gone everywhere else: the face, the swaddle, the new blue emerging in her irises. Everywhere but the fingers. As if looking at them directly would cost something he couldn't afford. The clicking. It had changed when he walked in. Elara had been listening to it all day--had mapped its rhythm, its tempo, its micro-variations--and when Marcus

crossed the threshold, the clicking accelerated. Not the smooth deepening that had occurred when Elara held the baby. This was sharper. Faster. Agitated, almost. And beneath the clicking, so faint that Elara wasn't sure she hadn't imagined it: the hum. A sustained tone, lower than the clicks, vibrating at the edge of perception. It had been there all day, buried under the household noise, but when Marcus arrived it rose--not in volume, in density--as though his presence had added a signal to a network that was already broadcasting. Nunnally's milky eyes, still faintly blue at the edges, had turned toward her father the moment he entered the room. The silent vowel formed on her lips. Ah. The same shape she had offered Elara. But the quality was different. Elara could feel it--not hear, feel--in the scars on her wrists: a shift in the resonance, a tightening, as though the frequency Nunnally was broadcasting had narrowed, focused, locked onto Marcus with an intensity that had not been present before. The baby was tracking her father the way a compass needle tracks north. Marcus held his daughter. He kissed her forehead. He murmured something Elara couldn't hear. And then he set her back in Evelyn's arms with a care that looked, to anyone else, like tenderness. Elara saw the relief in his shoulders when he let go. She didn't understand any of it. Not the smell. Not the clicking. Not the way her scars burned pleasantly when the baby was near and cooled when she moved away. Not the way Marcus Hart carried himself like a man transporting something fragile and dangerous across a room, trying not to look at it, trying not to drop it. But she filed it all. Every detail. In the place where a normal teenager kept song lyrics and social media passwords, Elara Voss kept observations, and the observations were accumulating into a shape she couldn't see yet but could feel forming--the way you can feel a storm before it arrives, not in the sky, but in the pressure behind your eyes. She put on her coat. She said goodnight. She thanked Dr. Hart for the opportunity. She walked to the bus stop in the dark, and for the first twelve minutes of the ride home the noise in her body stayed quiet--the beautiful, impossible silence that the Hart house had given her--and then, somewhere on Route 7, between Falls Church and the apartment where her aunt kept the lights low and the questions lower, it returned. Gradual. A whisper at

first. Then a hum. Then the full grinding static, filling her bones, her wrists, the base of her skull. Elara pressed her forehead against the cold bus window and thought: Not because of the science. Not because of the internship. Not because of Dr. Hart or the sequencer or the filing system. Because the pain had stopped. And it would not stop again until she walked back through that door.

Synapse 03

The Watcher

\[Source: Private journal / Elara Voss / Handwritten\]

Location: Voss Apartment, Falls Church, VA

Found in wall cavity behind bookshelf, 2028. 37 entries, Jan 7-Mar 14, 2026.

Jan 7 -- 11:14 PM

First day at Hart residence.

Dr. Evelyn Hart. Brilliant. Exhausted. Working off-book on a regeneration vector. She doesn't know who I am. Doesn't know my mother designed the delivery system she's using.

Baby: Nunnally, 3 wks 4 days. Bilateral upper-limb absence, visual/auditory impairment. Two digits on left nub since vector admin. Growth rate 3x published models.

Internal sounds: rhythmic clicking, ~72 bpm at rest. I've been listening to it all day. It's calming and I don't know why.

Jan 7 -- 11:31 PM

Husband came home at 7. Colonel Marcus Hart, Army. He smelled wrong. Not bad. Sweet. Under his clothes, in his skin.

He didn't look at the baby's hands.

He held her right. Kissed her. Said the right things. But he didn't look at the part that's growing. And the clicking changed when he was near -- faster, tighter.

I'm recording it.

Jan 7 -- 11:58 PM

I need to write this down.

When I held the baby, the pain stopped.

Not the grief. Not the five years of aunt-who-doesn't-ask. The physical pain. The static. The noise in my bones since Lab 4. Since the mist. Since Mom.

It stopped. Completely. First time in five years.

And when I left the house it came back.

Scientific explanation: baby's tissue produces low-frequency output (~18 Hz, infrasound). My scars are from exposure to an unclassified compound. Possible that baby's output interacts w/ residual compound in my tissue, dampening chronic inflammatory response.

That's the scientific explanation.

The truth is simpler. When I held her, I felt like I was home.

*The compound is patient. The compound has time.
But you don't have to wait.*

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*A GOTNA Novel - Book One of a Trilogy
The story continues in Book Two: THE FREQUENCY*